



In school, so much learning happens through listening. Teachers give directions out loud, explain new concepts verbally, and are constantly asking students to talk about what they're learning. This could be in a whole-class discussion, a small group or with a partner. When a child has trouble listening, they may miss important instructions, feel confused about what to do, or have a harder time joining in classroom conversations.

Listening readiness is something that parents can help support at home. Simple, playful listening games give children practice hearing, processing and responding to oral information in a fun way.

Listening Games



1) Simon Says

How to Play

1. Choose one person to be Simon
2. Simon stands facing all the other players.
3. Simon gives two different commands.
 - A “Simon Says” command (e.g. “Simon says clap your hands”). Players must follow this command.
 - A regular command without “Simon Says” (e.g. Clap your hands”). Players should NOT follow this type of command. They must stay still.
4. If a player follows a regular command, one that does NOT begin with “Simon Says,” they are out for the round and sit down.
4. The last player still in the game is the winner.
5. The winner get to be Simon in the next round.



2) Which One is the Odd One Out

How to Play

1. Say a list of five words aloud.
 - Four of the words should belong to the same category (e.g. red, orange, purple, yellow)
 - One word should NOT belong to that category (e.g. dog).

2. Your child must listen carefully and identify the word that does not fit the category.

Example: You would say red, orange, dog, purple, yellow. Your child would say that “dog” was the word that doesn’t belong.

Ideas for Categories

Members of a family (e.g. mom, aunt, cousin, etc.)

Holidays and special occasions

Things we do for fun

Clothing (or more specific categories like “types of hats” or “summer clothes)

Foods

Things you find in a bedroom

Animals

Shapes

Things that move

Things you do in school

Toys

Books



3) How Many Things Did You Hear

How to Play

1. Play this game while taking a walk outside, sitting on a porch, or near an open window.
2. Take turns listening carefully to the sounds around you.
3. When it’s your turn, name one sound you hear (e.g. a car door closing, leaves rustling, a dog barking, a train going by).
4. Keep going around the group to see how many different sounds everyone can identify together.

Game Extension

After a few turns you could ask the following questions:

- Which sound was the quietest?
- Which sound was the loudest?
- Which sound did you hear more often?

Challenge Versions

1. Remember the order

After everyone has named several sounds, pick one person to repeat all the sounds in the exact order they were said.

Example: “We heard: a car door, leaves rustling, a bird chirping, a dog barking.”

2. Sort the Sounds

After a few rounds, ask a player to group the sounds into categories, such as

- Animal sounds: birds, dogs, squirrels moving in a tree
- Transportation sounds: Cars, trains, buses, honking, airplane
- People Sounds: talking, footsteps, laughter, singing

3. Sound Detective

One person closes their eyes. A different player makes a sound (e.g. snapping their fingers, jingling keys, closing a gate).

The listener must guess the sound.



4) Freeze Dance

How to Play

1. Turn on some music, and have everyone start dancing.
2. At any moment, stop the music with NO warning.
3. As soon as the music stops, all players must freeze in place.
4. Anyone who moves after the music stops is out for that round.

Challenge Versions

1. Freeze in a Silly Pose

Players freeze in the silliest or funniest pose they can think of. They can also make funny faces to go along with the pose!

2. Freeze in Slow Motion

When the music stops, players pretend they are moving in slow motion until they come to a complete freeze.

3. Freeze on a Color

Before starting, place or identify a few colored objects (toys, furniture) around the room. When the music stops, call out a color and players must touch something of that color and then freeze.

4. Freeze and Follow a Direction

Once everyone freezes, give a quick direction that players must follow when the music starts again such as:

- “Dance like a robot!”
- “Move with your hands and feet on the floor!”

- “Hop instead of dance!”



5) I Saw it at the Zoo (more advanced game)

How to Play

1. Player 1 begins by saying,
“I went to the zoo and saw a monkey.”
2. Player 2 then repeats the sentence exactly and adds a new animal.

Example: “I went to the zoo and saw a monkey and an elephant.”

3. On each turn, the next player must:
 - Repeat all the animals in the correct order, then
 - Add a new animal to the list.
4. Players may not repeat an animal that has already been said.
5. The game continues to see how many animals everyone can remember in the right sequence.

Alternative Versions

- I went to the grocery store and bought a...
- I went to the park and saw a...
- I went outside and saw a...

Feel free to use a theme your child enjoys (e.g. sports, foods, toys, colors, etc.)

Challenge Versions

1. Add an Action

Players must repeat the list and add a short action for each animal.

Example: I went to the zoo and saw a monkey swinging, an elephant stomping and a lion roaring.”

2. Switch the Category

Midway through the game, switch the theme but keep the sequence going.

Example: I went to the zoo and saw a monkey, an elephant, a lion...and an apple.

6) Listen & Draw (very advanced activity)

This is a great game to see how well your child is listening. You will want to make sure your child understands directions (up, down, bottom, middle, right, left, corner, etc.) before playing the game. You will want to simplify the game in the beginning by giving just a few simple instructions.

Easier Examples:

- Write the number 2.
- Write your name
- Draw a sun

Harder Examples

- Draw a house in the middle of the paper
- Draw a sun in the upper right top corner
- Draw a bird on the left side of the sun
- Draw a tree on the right side of the house

Hardest Examples

- Write your name in the top left corner and then draw a circle in the middle of the paper
- Draw a square in the middle of the circle and then color the circle blue
- Draw a smiley face in the bottom right corner and then a sad face in the bottom left corner